

can throw the budget out the window if you're not careful. By setting a daily limit for how much you can spend on food, you can keep this variable expense under control too. If one day you go out for that special (and more expensive) lunch, then you'll have to make do with a smaller breakfast and budget dinner to make the day's budget balance.

A BALANCED VACATION

Like so many things in life, your vacation is about balance. You're on vacation, so treat yourself to the simple pleasures in life you have worked hard and saved up for. You want to return home energized, refreshed, and with lots of happy memories. Don't waste time scrimping and saving on every little thing. But don't throw caution to the wind and return home to a series of surprising bills, statement shock, and uncontrollable debt. Make sure your vacation is pleasurable, from the initial planning stages to the lifetime of memories afterward.

— Nora Dunn



3 Easy Steps to Finding Great Airfare Deals

Finding the cheapest ticket can be a confusing process. However, by understanding the system and the motivations behind pricing, you can develop a strategy to consistently find a good deal.

1. No search engine is better than any other

The first thing you must accept is that no fare search engine is the single best. All fare search engines in the United States, including the one in a travel agent's office, scan the same database using identical search algorithms.

2. When you fly is the most important factor

Flying off season, overnight, during the week (usually Tuesday or Wednesday), with a companion, to and from less popular or more inconvenient airports, and including more transfers in the itinerary, are all factors that commonly reduce a ticket's price.